that the soul is neither known as an object, or in the ways in which objects are known. Objects need to be illuminated by something external, namely, consciousness, but the self-conscious soul is always directly aware of itself.

When the soul is subject to rebirth it is associated with a 'subtle body' consisting of residual impressions that are the good and bad ***karma*** produced by actions performed with some goal in view. It is the constant presence of the soul that guarantees the continuity of the same individual through a series of lives. Understanding the true nature of the soul is widely held to be a factor contributing to release from rebirth. Buddhists think that belief in its existence is at the root of human ills.

According to ***Advaita Vedanta***, the ***atman*** is featureless, inactive awareness. It is self-evident and reveals itself in every conscious act. It is identical with ***Brahman***, the foundational reality. Realisation of the unity of all souls means liberation from the series of births. For theistic ***Vedanta***, souls are individual centres of self-awareness, the point of whose existence is the adoration of god (see ***Ramanuja***). Both schools hold that soul may become misidentified with mind, body, and circumstances including one's caste. It may then be regarded as an agent who experiences the fruits of its actions. Release from rebirth involves the recovery and restoration of true identity.

According to ***Nyaya-Vaisheshika***, souls are non-physical and non-conscious principles of identity that explain our ability to remember and our capacity to synthesise the present variety of experiences into a unity. They are eternal and everywhere, though localisable in bodies. Thoughts, desires and acts of will cannot stand alone: there must be an enduring subject to which they belong. The existence of this non-mental principle of identity can only be known by inference. Not being conscious, it cannot make itself known. (Some ***Nyaya*** thinkers say that it